

Chapter 131_3 - Following

After finishing the meal, the cold air was driven away, and she was warm and sweating all over. Ning Fuyi got up to clear the bowls and chopsticks but was pressed down by the woman, who snatched the dishes away and went to wash them herself.

Ning Fuyi could only sit with empty hands, lifting Yuange'er into the cradle and pushing her to play. Children love to play most, and soon she wasn't shy anymore, sweetly calling "Sister Ning" with every breath.

"Mama, Yuange'er wants to eat sweet soup¹!" Yuange'er suddenly called out.

The woman wiped her hands and walked over, smiling as she went to look for pots and bowls. However, she immediately clicked her tongue and said apologetically: "Yuange'er, be good. There's not enough firewood today—Mama will make it for you tomorrow."

Hearing this, though Yuange'er said nothing, her little mouth drooped, clearly displeased. Seeing this, Ning Fuyi quickly stood up: "Aunt Luo, let me go."

The woman quickly grabbed her, her thick eyebrows rising: "You're also a young girl. These desolate mountains are dangerous—how can I let you go? Don't worry, this girl is just being greedy. She can bear it—it's nothing!"

"I'm quite strong." Ning Fuyi narrowed her smiling eyes, turned her body and imperceptibly withdrew from her grasp, smoothly picked up the wood-chopping knife by the door, and walked out in the blink of an eye.

Leaving the woman's calls behind her, she walked up the mountain along the road leading out of the city.

Her internal injuries had healed considerably these past few days, and she didn't need to worry about using immortal power. She soon found a grove, felt the tree trunks, and satisfactorily raised the wood knife.

A white shadow flashed behind her, the scent of flowers drifting over. The white shadow stood with hands behind her back, wordlessly stopping not far away.

Ning Fuyi put down the wood knife and strode deeper into the forest. After finding an open area, she continued to raise her hand.

The person behind moved again, following her step by step. Ning Fuyi felt like she had grown a tail. She simply ran toward an even deeper place, hiding her aura midway and flying into the trees.

When that figure strode beneath her feet, she quietly slipped down and tapped Chu Qingqiu's shoulder from behind, causing the woman to instantly draw her white bone² and turn around fiercely.

Chu Qingqiu paused, her expression softening as she lowered her gaze and put away the white bone.

"I thought you were planning to ignore me forever," Chu Qingqiu spoke first. Mottled moonlight filtered through the treetops, sprinkling on her shoulders.

"What if I really ignored you?" Ning Fuyi turned the wood knife in her hand.

Chu Qingqiu shook her head, her gaze looking at the moonlight at her feet: "I don't know. Perhaps I'd keep following you."

"Yiyi, I've spent my whole life running away. Is it your turn now?" Chu Qingqiu said gently. "We're already struggling enough."

"Yes, truly struggling." Ning Fuyi smiled. In past and present lives, it was too difficult, too difficult.

Chu Qingqiu slowly approached. In the moonlight, her face was whiter than the moon disc, her eyes brighter than the stars. Ning Fuyi was lost in gazing at those eyes when suddenly she felt a tightness around her body. She was immediately pulled into the air and her back crashed against a tree trunk, bound firmly to the tree by Flying Feather Rope³.

"Chu Qingqiu!" she called out quickly. "What do you mean by this?"

The woman walked toward her in the moonlight, her eyes sparkling with tears.

She shook her head and said softly: "I don't want to let you go anymore."

"If you never remembered for a lifetime, I could still endure. But now that you've remembered, I don't want to let you go."

"You were the one who forced me to find you again. I finally overcame reason, finally indulged myself once, but you want to leave again." Her voice was calm, but her agitation was hard to hide.

"Didn't you say you'd treat me well? Is ignoring me treating me well?"

"I'm sorry, I don't intend to leave you," Ning Fuyi said. "I'm just... afraid."

"Without the comparison of those memories, I would never have realized how deeply the demonic energy has affected me. What I thought was myself in my previous life was actually a monster constructed from demonic energy." Ning Fuyi lowered her head. "If..."

The grass in her vision suddenly twisted and distorted, then a tear fell, the teardrop hitting the grass tip and bouncing into several parts.

Chu Qingqiu's fingertips moved, suddenly raising her hand to place a warm palm on top of her head, gently stroking it and wiping away her tears.

Chu Qingqiu wasn't good at comforting people, nor was she good at being gentle with others. This tear-wiping was clumsy, almost poking into Ning Fuyi's eyes.

She snapped her fingers, and the Flying Feather Rope instantly untied. Ning Fuyi's body slid down, half-kneeling in the green grass as overwhelming fallen leaves scattered from the tree due to her pulling.

However, Chu Qingqiu manifested a pure white umbrella in her hand, blocking all the withered leaves.

At this moment, her calmness and strength were extremely reassuring. The gardenia fragrance covered even the smell of grass, and her whole being was bathed in her scent.

"The prophecy about the world-destroyer is indeed true. In the previous life, Ning Changfeng and I also learned of it by chance. This is why I insisted on killing you," Chu Qingqiu said slowly. "But you needn't fear. I've seen the prophecy that Penglai⁴ produced—it doesn't refer to you in this life."

"The tear moles⁵," Ning Fuyi murmured.

"Right, so let's set that aside for now," Chu Qingqiu spoke clearly, her hand still steadily holding the umbrella, sheltering them from all wind.

"I initially wanted to kill you, thinking that as long as you were gone, the world would be peaceful," Chu Qingqiu said slowly. "And indeed, it was Ning Changfeng who stopped me. Though I didn't agree with her twisted reasoning, I was indeed shaken."

"You were just a baby then—how could you know you would become a demon, how could you know you'd be some world-destroyer? Killing you might be blameless toward the world, but it would certainly wrong you."

"Moreover, after you grew up, Ning Changfeng actually knelt down and pleaded, begging me to give you a chance. She said she had a way to help you overcome this life's tribulations, or perhaps when you were reborn, everything would change."

"She was gambling—gambling that she could complete the Reincarnation Array⁶, gambling that your fate in this life would change. I initially thought she had gone mad, but she stubbornly actually completed the prototype of the Reincarnation Array, and obsessively hid almost all of her cultivation bit by bit in your body, praying that in some unknown distant future, they could save your life."

"She actually loved you that much—willing to use a lifetime of madness to exchange for the slightest possibility of you living. I have to say, I was somewhat admiring."

"I didn't interfere again, coldly watching her step by step send herself to the Yellow Springs⁷. At that time, I thought she brought it upon herself. I thought I would feel no sorrow, but when I learned the tragic news, I actually stood dazed for half a day, suddenly feeling that in this vast world, I was ultimately left alone."

"I thought I would truly be without emotion, but in that instant I actually felt a faint hatred toward you—hating that you had harmed my only friend. Moreover, I knew she had no possibility of survival, so when you begged me to save her, when you asked for my help, I paid no attention."

"That was the first time I felt sadness and hatred. I regretted it deeply. I'm sorry," Chu Qingqiu lowered her gaze.

Ning Fuyi said nothing.

"So I began helping her complete the Reincarnation Array. After who knows how long, I finally drew out a complete Reincarnation Array, but nightmare also came with it. This formation violated the Heavenly Dao⁸, so I was forcibly pulled into chaos to receive the most severe punishment."

"Later you mistakenly entered the chaos, and the Emotionless Way⁹ was completely broken. Though I wasn't conscious of it, I dreamed entirely of you then, often needing to practice cultivation to suppress those absurd thoughts. Later still, when you and I left the chaos, you forgot those memories, and I thought I could hide those feelings and your memories together."

"The breaking of the Emotionless Way and the punishment left me severely injured, nearly costing my life. But I still endured it. When I could finally get up, this world was already like a candle in the wind. I was worried about the Reincarnation Array and secretly worried about you, so I pretended to go make trouble for you and simply let you capture me into the Demon Cave."

"What happened afterward you should also remember. Your demonic energy couldn't activate the Reincarnation Array, so you nearly went mad. You also recalled the events in the chaos through this, thinking I had come to eliminate you, so for my sake, you simply took your own life before me."

"It was then that I completely and utterly fell in love with you," Chu Qingqiu shed a clear tear.

"At that time, the world was about to be destroyed, the six realms¹⁰ were devastated, and there was no turning back. So I decided to activate the Reincarnation Array myself and let everything return to the beginning."

"I couldn't believe you had already become Bianhua flowers¹¹, so despite the underworld's obstruction, I searched through the entire Bianhua grove and found your soul, swearing to bring you back."

"Fortunately, I succeeded. The person who activates the formation won't lose their memories. Just when you were unconscious from Ning Changfeng's death, I took you from Liu Wenzhu, and while treating your injuries, I used half of the divine flower's cultivation to destroy the curse on your body."

Chu Qingqiu seemed tired from speaking. She stopped and looked steadily into Ning Fuyi's eyes, reaching out to stroke the back of her head and pull her into her arms, gently patting her back.

"Counting it all up, we've already missed each other so many times..."

Her eyes were full of tenderness: "Demonic energy, curses—we can face them all together. After all, we're already dancing on knife edges. Even if we die together, it's far better than being separated."

"Don't you think so, Yiyi?" she asked carefully.

Footnotes:

- ¹ **Sweet soup (饴汤)** - A traditional Chinese sweet soup, often made with malt sugar or honey
- ² **White bone (白骨)** - Chu Qingqiu's signature weapon, likely made from immortal bone and used as both flute and weapon
- ³ **Flying Feather Rope (飞羽索)** - Chu Qingqiu's binding weapon that can transform into flowing ribbons
- ⁴ **Penglai (蓬莱)** - The celestial realm that serves as the primary antagonist
- ⁵ **Tear moles (泪痣)** - The distinctive beauty marks under Ning Fuyi's eyes that were mentioned in the prophecy
- ⁶ **Reincarnation Array (轮回阵)** - The magical formation created by Ning Changfeng to bring back the dead
- ⁷ **Yellow Springs (黄泉)** - The Chinese underworld, realm of the dead
- ⁸ **Heavenly Dao (天道)** - The Way of Heaven, the natural order that governs the universe
- ⁹ **Emotionless Way (无情道)** - Chu Qingqiu's cultivation path that required her to suppress all emotions
- ¹⁰ **Six realms (六界)** - The six domains of existence in the story's cosmology
- ¹¹ **Bianhua flowers (彼岸花)** - Red spider lilies, flowers associated with death and the afterlife in East Asian culture